



False start: The lack of preparation time and poor match fitness may absolve Manolo Marquez from much of the blame in his debut tournament as India's manager.

NAGARA GOPAL

Nightmare start for Manolo era after tough Syrian lesson

Syria lifts maiden Intercontinental Cup as defending champion India **fails to impress** under new coach Manolo Marquez.

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He termed his debut match "a boring game." What were Manolo Marquez's thoughts about his second match as India manager? That may be left to speculation, as the All India Football Federation (AIFF) decided against a post-match press conference after India lost 3-0 to Syria at the GMC Balayogi Athletic Stadium on September 9, thus failing to retain the

Intercontinental Cup title.

The Spaniard may be spared from strong judgement after the Intercontinental Cup debacle if factors like preparation time and match fitness are considered. But the tri-nation tournament served as an open book, revealing the issues plaguing Indian football, with the Blue Tigers failing to find the net even once in two matches. The fact that it played its campaign opener against a

lower-ranked team in Mauritius makes the narrative grimmer.

On a positive note, India showed glimpses of its potential in both matches. Starting slow against both Mauritius and Syria, the Blue Tigers created some goal-scoring chances but failed to add the finishing touch. This brings forward the first topic that the Spaniard needs to discuss with his men — starting slow. At the professional level, requiring an entire